IMPORTING GOODS

Importing (see pp.212–215) may offer the widest choice of suppliers and products, but expect some issues with speed and reliability of supply: some countries, such as China, can change import/export terms at very short notice. It can also be harder to build a relationship with a supplier who is far away.

- **Check whether any** special licences are needed: for example, some countries prohibit the export or import of antiques without a licence.
- **Assess how much** tax or import duty is to be paid, and agree trading terms with your supplier.
- **Set a delivery date** with the supplier and agree the means of delivery.
- **Discuss potential problems** in advance; agree what will happen, if, for example, goods do not arrive on time.
- **Work out how** potentially longer shipping times might affect your business processes or impact on customers.
- **Investigate ethical standards**: are factory conditions acceptable? Is the supplier environmentally friendly?
- **Make sure you understand** every link of your supply chain (see pp.180–181).

Major national suppliers

Items that you need to order regularly and in bulk may be easier to source from major national suppliers. While cheaper, your competitors may be able to buy the same stock.

Sourced internationally

Items produced overseas may be cheaper. However, you will have to factor in a longer lead-time and may need to outsource checking of your items before they are shipped.